

European Institute of Innovation and Technology (EIT) Communities in Europe: A Comprehensive Overview

Introduction and EIT Mission

The **European Institute of Innovation and Technology (EIT)** was established in 2008 as an independent body of the European Union to bolster Europe's capacity for innovation ¹. Its founding mission is to integrate the "*knowledge triangle*" – higher education, research, and business – in order to drive sustainable European economic growth and competitiveness through innovation ² ³. In practice, the EIT nurtures entrepreneurial talent and supports the development of new ideas from lab to market, focusing on pressing global challenges. It does so primarily by orchestrating dynamic pan-European partnerships known as *Knowledge and Innovation Communities* (KICs) that bring together leading universities, research labs, industry partners, and startups ⁴. By uniting over 2,400 partner organizations across more than 70 innovation hubs, the EIT has become "*Europe's largest innovation ecosystem*," supporting innovators in domains ranging from climate and energy to health, food, and digitization ⁵. The ultimate purpose of the EIT is to foster innovation-driven growth and skilled job creation in the EU, in line with broader European goals for a green, digital, and competitive economy ⁶ ⁷.

Governance Structure and EU Integration

Legal Status and EU Framework: The EIT is structured as an EU body with its own legal personality, operating under a dedicated EU regulation (first adopted in 2008 and recast in 2021) that defines its mission and framework ⁴ ⁸. Importantly, the Institute is an integral part of the EU's research and innovation funding program. Under *Horizon Europe* (2021–2027), the EIT falls within *Pillar 3: "Innovative Europe"*, alongside the European Innovation Council (EIC) ⁹. It is allocated a budget of approximately €3 billion from Horizon Europe to strengthen innovation ecosystems and advance entrepreneurial education across Europe ¹⁰. In return, the EIT is expected to contribute to Horizon Europe's strategic objectives – for example, promoting Europe's "*open strategic autonomy*" in key technologies, accelerating the green and digital transitions (e.g. European Green Deal goals), and building a more resilient and inclusive society ⁷. The KICs are formally recognized as "*Institutionalised European Partnerships*" under Horizon Europe, meaning they are long-term public-private partnerships tasked with delivering clear EU-wide impact in their thematic areas ¹¹.

Governing Bodies: The EIT's governance is designed to be both *flexible* and *accountable*. Its principal decision-making body is the **EIT Governing Board**, an independent group of 15 high-level members from academia, business, and innovation sectors (plus one European Commission observer) ¹². The Governing Board sets the EIT's strategic direction and is responsible for selecting, evaluating, funding, and (if necessary) discontinuing the KICs ¹². It approves each KIC's multi-annual strategy and annual business plans, ensuring alignment with EU objectives. Day-to-day executive management is led by the **EIT Director** (based at EIT headquarters in Budapest, Hungary) and a small management team ¹³ ⁸. To enhance

coordination with EU Member States, a **Member State Representatives Group (MSRG)** was established in 2021 as an advisory body under the updated EIT Regulation ¹⁴. The MSRG, composed of delegates from each EU country and Horizon-associated state, advises on strategically important issues (such as launching or terminating KICs) and helps align EIT initiatives with national and regional innovation policies ¹⁴ ¹⁵. The EIT also maintains a liaison office in Brussels to facilitate interaction with EU institutions and other stakeholders ¹⁶.

Autonomy and Accountability: While the EIT is EU-funded, the KICs enjoy substantial operational autonomy. Each KIC is structured as a separate legal entity (often a non-profit association or company) and has flexibility to design its internal organization and governance in the way that best suits its innovation strategy ¹⁷. This autonomy allows KICs to be agile and industry-driven; for example, KICs have their own CEOs and governance boards with member representatives ¹⁸. The relationship between the EIT and each KIC is governed by a **Partnership Agreement** and grant agreements, which set out performance targets, funding commitments, and monitoring mechanisms. The EIT uses a results-based approach to hold KICs accountable for EU funds – it monitors KIC outputs (new products, start-ups, trained graduates, etc.) and conducts periodic evaluations (e.g. after 3 years, 7 years, etc.) ¹⁹ ²⁰. The Governing Board can decide to scale down or discontinue support to a KIC if it underperforms or once its partnership mandate expires (after about 7–15 years) ²⁰. In 2024, for instance, the first-wave KICs were undergoing final review as their 15-year mark approached ²⁰. This governance model attempts to balance the KICs’ freedom to innovate with oversight to ensure EIT funding delivers European added value.

Knowledge and Innovation Communities (KICs) Overview

Concept and Purpose: The EIT’s core operational mechanism is its network of **Knowledge and Innovation Communities**, which are large-scale public-private partnerships addressing specific societal challenges. Each KIC is a mission-driven consortium that brings together *“the excellence of the sector at a European level”* – including universities and research institutes, companies (from industry giants to SMEs), start-ups, investors, as well as city/regional authorities and NGOs ²¹ ²². By uniting these actors, KICs aim to foster the entire innovation chain: from education and talent development, to technology research projects, to business incubation and acceleration. The first KICs were launched in 2010, and new ones have been added in subsequent waves, each focusing on a priority theme where innovation is needed (climate change, sustainable energy, health, etc.). Table 1 provides an overview of the nine EIT KICs active as of 2025, including their thematic focus areas, launch year, and main headquarters.

Table 1. EIT Knowledge and Innovation Communities (KICs): Domains, Launch Years, and Headquarters

KIC Name	Thematic Focus	Launch Year	Headquarters (Main Office)
EIT Climate-KIC	Climate change mitigation & adaptation; climate innovation	2010	Amsterdam, Netherlands ²³
EIT Digital	Digital technologies and ICT	2010	Brussels, Belgium ²⁴
EIT InnoEnergy (KIC InnoEnergy)	Sustainable energy & cleantech	2010	Eindhoven, Netherlands ²⁵

KIC Name	Thematic Focus	Launch Year	Headquarters (Main Office)
EIT Health	Health and active ageing	2015	Munich (Garching), Germany ²⁶ ²⁷
EIT RawMaterials	Sustainable raw materials & circular economy	2015	Berlin, Germany ²⁸
EIT Food	Sustainable food and agritech	2016	Leuven, Belgium ²⁹
EIT Manufacturing	Advanced manufacturing and Industry 4.0	2019	Paris-Saclay, France ³⁰ ³¹
EIT Urban Mobility	Urban mobility and smart cities	2019	Barcelona, Spain ³²
EIT Culture & Creativity	Cultural and creative industries	2022	Cologne, Germany ³³

Sources: EIT official site and KIC websites ³⁴ ²⁹ ³³. (Note: Launch year refers to the year the KIC was designated by the EIT; operational activities typically began the following year. Headquarters denote the legal/administrative seat of the KIC consortium.)

Each KIC is designed to operate as a long-term (7–15 year) initiative, with the expectation that it will become *financially sustainable* over time and continue its mission beyond EU funding ²⁰. The initial wave of KICs – Climate-KIC, InnoEnergy, and (EIT) Digital – were selected in late 2009 and became operational in 2010 ³⁵. Subsequent waves followed the EIT’s **Strategic Innovation Agendas**: for example, calls in 2014 led to KICs in *Health* and *Raw Materials* (launched 2015), the 2016 call added *Food* and *Manufacturing* (launched by 2017–2019), and a 2018 call created *Urban Mobility* (launched 2019) ³⁶ ³⁷. Most recently, in 2022, the EIT inaugurated **EIT Culture & Creativity**, targeting Europe’s cultural and creative sectors ³⁸. A call is currently underway for a tenth KIC in the field of *water and marine technologies* (EIT Water) ³⁹, reflecting the EIT’s alignment with emerging EU priorities like water sustainability.

Structure and Operations: Despite their diverse themes, all KICs share a similar operational model. Each KIC is organized around several regional *co-location centres* or **Innovation Hubs** across Europe, which serve as physical clusters of partners ⁴⁰ ⁴¹. For example, EIT Health established six co-location centers in cities including London, Stockholm, Paris, Barcelona, Heidelberg, and Rotterdam to cover different parts of Europe ⁴². These hubs host KIC activities—such as innovation projects, start-up incubators, hackathons, trainings, and networking events—enabling close collaboration among local partners. A small central or head office (see Table 1) coordinates the KIC’s overall strategy, financial management, and cross-node programs. KIC partner organizations typically pay a membership fee or contribute resources in-kind, and in return gain access to the community’s funding calls, labs, testbeds, mentorship, and EU-wide network. Notably, each KIC is free to choose the legal form and governance that suits it best (subject to EIT Board approval). Some are incorporated as **international non-profit associations** under Belgian or French law (e.g. EIT Digital as an *IVZW* in Belgium ²⁴, EIT Manufacturing as an *Association* in France), while others operate as **companies** (e.g. EIT RawMaterials founded a GmbH in Germany ⁴³). All KICs appoint a CEO or Director and have their own boards representing core partners ¹⁸. This flexible structure allows KICs to adapt their working methods to their industry’s needs – an autonomy explicitly encouraged by the EIT’s design ⁴⁴.

Each KIC carries out a portfolio of activities grouped broadly into the EIT's three pillars: **(1) Innovation projects**, which bring together partners to develop new products or services (often co-funded R&D projects aimed at market applications); **(2) Education programs**, which include entrepreneurial MSc and PhD programs branded with the “EIT Label” (see Section on Education), professional training, and outreach to students; and **(3) Business creation services**, such as venture incubators, accelerators, challenge prizes, and investor matchmaking to launch and scale start-ups ⁴⁵. By integrating these functions, the KICs seek to create innovation ecosystems that can convert knowledge into tangible innovation and new businesses more efficiently than traditional siloed efforts. Over a decade of operations, the KIC model has been credited with “breeding entrepreneurial talent” and “connecting partners, investors, and expertise” across Europe’s innovation landscape ⁴⁶ ⁴⁷. However, the model has also been experimental, and each KIC has evolved its strategy in response to successes and challenges (discussed later).

Funding Mechanisms and Financial Model

EIT Grants and Co-Funding: The EIT provides financial support to each KIC primarily through annual or multi-annual grants, which are governed by Horizon Europe rules and performance-based agreements. The crucial principle, enshrined in the EIT Regulation, is that EIT funding **must not exceed 25%** of a KIC’s total budget on average ⁴⁸. In other words, the majority (at least 75%) of each KIC’s funding must come from *non-EIT sources*, such as the partner organizations’ own contributions, membership fees, national or regional public funding (including structural funds), and private investments ⁴⁸. This co-funding model is intended to leverage additional resources and ensure that KIC activities have buy-in from stakeholders. In practice, during a KIC’s initial years the EIT grant may cover a larger share of costs, but over time the KIC is expected to attract more external funding (industry sponsorships, revenues from services or intellectual property, equity returns, etc.), moving toward financial sustainability ²⁰ ⁴⁸. The grant agreements incentivize this by requiring KICs to progressively increase their co-funding rate. For example, by 2024 the first three KICs had built substantial revenue streams and investor support such that their EIT grants were being phased out after 15 years ²⁰. This “EIT funding as seed funding” approach is a hallmark of the EIT model, distinguishing it from traditional 100%-funded research projects.

Budget Allocation: Under Horizon Europe, the EIT’s total budget for 2021–2027 is €2.965 billion ⁴⁹. About 96% of this is dedicated to funding the KICs (both existing and new) ⁴⁹. Importantly, the EIT must channel specific minimum shares to certain priority actions. For instance, *at least 10% (up to 15%)* of the funding is earmarked for the **Regional Innovation Scheme (RIS)** – a program to support innovators in “widening” or modest-performing regions (explained below) ⁴⁹. Additionally, up to 7% may be used for *cross-KIC cooperation activities* (e.g. joint projects between KICs, or support for a KIC after its core funding period ends), and up to 3% for a new pilot initiative to build innovation capacity in higher education (the *HEI Initiative*) ⁴⁹. The EIT Governing Board can adjust these allocations within the limits set by the Horizon Europe Decision. Funds are awarded through competitive processes: each KIC submits annual Business Plans with proposed activities and Key Performance Indicators (KPIs), which the EIT assesses for their alignment with the Strategic Agenda and their past performance. Once approved, a *Grant Agreement* is signed and funds are disbursed (typically a mix of advance and performance-based payments). The EIT uses robust monitoring to track how KICs spend these grants – for example, ensuring that funds directly support innovation, education, or startup creation activities (as opposed to general overhead) ⁵⁰ ⁵¹. The list of grant recipients is published for transparency ⁵². Notably, KICs have flexibility to sub-grant or invest the EIT funds into partner projects, startups (some KICs take equity stakes in ventures), scholarships, etc., following their own internal calls and selection processes, which are themselves monitored by the EIT ⁵³.

⁵⁴ .

EIT Regional Innovation Scheme (RIS): A significant funding mechanism to ensure geographic balance is the **EIT RIS**, introduced in 2014 and expanded over the past decade ⁵⁵ ⁵⁶. The RIS earmarks a portion of each KIC's activities and budget for EU countries and regions that are classified as “*modest or moderate innovators*” in the European Innovation Scoreboard (primarily in Central, Eastern, and Southern Europe). The aim is to bridge the innovation gap by onboarding partners from these regions, running outreach programs, and establishing local **EIT Hubs**. By 2017, the EIT RIS network had grown to 18 countries ⁵⁷, and it has continued to scale under Horizon Europe. In late 2024, the EIT launched 16 new “*EIT Community Hubs*” in countries such as Bulgaria, Croatia, Estonia, Latvia, Malta, Slovenia, as well as in Ukraine and Western Balkans states ⁵⁸ ⁵⁹. These national hubs act as one-stop shops for local entrepreneurs and organizations to access all KIC opportunities under one roof, thereby increasing EIT's visibility and uptake in those regions ⁵⁸ ⁶⁰. According to the EIT Governing Board, the RIS has been “one of the most successful instruments” for widening participation: as of 2024, about 60% of all EIT activity participations involve organizations from RIS-eligible countries (significantly higher than the ~40% under Horizon Europe overall) ⁵⁶ ⁶¹. The mid-term evaluation of EIT RIS highlighted that hundreds of start-ups from these regions have been supported and many exceeded expectations in commercial success ⁶² ⁶³. In sum, the EIT's funding model deliberately spreads resources across Europe, requiring co-investment from partners and focusing on capacity-building where it's most needed, all while keeping the KICs accountable to EU strategic goals.

Geographic Distribution and Innovation Hubs

Pan-European Reach: The EIT Community is expressly pan-European in footprint. By design, each KIC consortium had to include at least three partner organizations from at least three different EU Member States (including at least one academic institution and one company) ⁶⁴. As the KICs have matured, they have grown their network of nodes to cover virtually all corners of the EU (and some associated countries). Today, **every EU Member State hosts at least one EIT Innovation Hub or co-location centre** ⁶⁵ ⁶⁶. The KIC hubs are typically in major innovation hotspots – for example, Climate-KIC operates from 13 hubs across Europe (e.g. Paris, Berlin, Stockholm, Bologna, etc.), InnoEnergy has offices spanning from Sweden to Spain, and Urban Mobility established regional hubs in cities like Prague, Munich, Copenhagen, Helmond, and Barcelona to cover different clusters of countries ⁴² ⁶⁷. In total, the EIT counts over **70 innovation hubs** (co-location centers) in its network, ensuring an “on-the-ground presence in every EU member state” to make innovation support accessible locally ⁶⁸ ⁶⁶. The hubs facilitate face-to-face collaboration, community building, and adaptation of EIT offerings to regional contexts. They often reside in innovation campuses or science parks (for instance, EIT Manufacturing's headquarters is at the Paris-Saclay science cluster ³⁰, and EIT Health's HQ is on TUM's campus in Munich ²⁶).

Regional Innovation Hubs (RIS Hubs): Complementing the KIC-run centers, the EIT has, via the RIS, fostered **EIT Community Hubs** in countries with historically lower innovation output. By late 2024, 16 such hubs were launched in a first wave (covering most EU-13 countries, Western Balkans, as well as Portugal and an outreach in Ukraine) ⁵⁸ ⁶⁹. These national hubs host representatives from multiple KICs together, acting as a unified EIT presence. For example, in Sofia, Bulgaria, an EIT Community Hub was opened to serve as a gateway for Bulgarian researchers and entrepreneurs to connect with EIT Climate-KIC, EIT Digital, etc., without needing to travel to the main co-location centers elsewhere ⁷⁰. The EIT Community Hubs organize local info days, innovation trainings, and startup competitions (often in the local language), thereby embedding EIT programs into national innovation ecosystems. Such efforts aim to mitigate the brain-drain or centralization of innovation in a few regions by *spreading innovation capacity more evenly across Europe*. Plans are in place to launch additional hubs in remaining widening countries (e.g. Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Slovakia, etc.) by 2025 ⁷¹.

Global Outreach: While the EIT's mandate is EU-focused, it has also piloted global outreach to connect European innovators abroad. In 2018, the EIT and its KICs established the **EIT Global Outreach Programme**, extending activities to markets like Silicon Valley (USA), Israel, and China ⁷². EIT has since set up liaison outposts such as the *EIT Hub Israel* (connecting European start-ups with Israel's tech ecosystem) ⁷³ and had initiatives in Silicon Valley. These help European start-ups soft-land in overseas markets and attract foreign investment into EIT ventures, as well as scout talent. Moreover, some KICs individually have global nodes (for instance, EIT Digital opened a hub in Silicon Valley, and EIT Climate-KIC ran projects in Africa through partner universities). Through Horizon Europe, the EIT can engage associated non-EU countries: the UK, Switzerland, and others have partners in the KICs (though the UK's participation was affected by Brexit, Climate-KIC for example relocated its legal seat from London to Amsterdam post-2020 ²³). Overall, the EIT's geography now spans all EU states and some beyond, illustrating a truly trans-European network of innovation. A *mapping of the EIT ecosystem* shows dense interconnections of hubs and partners across Europe ⁷⁴ – a deliberate antidote to the fragmentation that previously hampered EU innovation.

Role in Innovation Ecosystems and Collaboration

The EIT and its KICs play a pivotal role in Europe's innovation ecosystems by acting as **integrators and enablers of collaboration** among the key actors of innovation. This stems from the EIT's founding vision of the *knowledge triangle integration*. In practical terms:

- **Academic-Industry Collaboration:** KICs provide structured platforms where universities and public research institutes work hand-in-hand with industry. Each KIC includes dozens of academic partners (often the top technical universities in Europe) and corporate partners (including multinational companies and local SMEs) within its thematic domain ⁷⁵ ⁵. By bringing these actors into the same governance and project teams, KICs help to bridge the gap between research and market. For instance, in EIT Digital, computer science faculties collaborate with telecom and software companies to translate new technologies (like AI or cybersecurity advances) into commercial applications ⁴⁷ ⁷⁶. In EIT Health, medical universities and hospitals co-develop solutions with pharma and medtech firms to address healthcare needs. This multi-stakeholder approach accelerates the innovation cycle and ensures that academic discoveries are guided by market insight, while companies gain early access to cutting-edge research and talent. Many KIC innovation projects require co-investment or in-kind contributions from industry partners, cementing their commitment.
- **SMEs and Start-ups:** A core emphasis of EIT KICs is supporting *small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs)* and start-ups as engines of innovation. Unlike some EU programs that primarily fund large research institutions, the KIC model actively involves start-ups and young companies in its community (often as partners or beneficiaries of KIC programs). Each KIC runs business creation programs such as **accelerators, incubators, mentorship, venture competitions, and seed investment funds** ⁴⁵. For example, Climate-KIC has its *Accelerator* program in multiple hubs to incubate climate-positive start-ups, and EIT InnoEnergy has a renowned portfolio of cleantech start-ups which it not only accelerates but also invests in directly (InnoEnergy often takes equity stakes in promising energy ventures). As a result, thousands of start-ups have been nurtured by the EIT Community (as detailed in a later section). KICs also facilitate SME participation in collaborative innovation projects, giving smaller firms access to university labs and corporate pilot opportunities that would be hard to obtain otherwise. According to the EIT, its *“pan-European ecosystem of more*

than 2,000 partners” includes many SMEs and high-growth start-ups alongside the big players ⁷⁷
⁵ . This broadens the reach of EU innovation funding to more agile, high-impact innovators.

- **Education and Talent Integration:** The EIT’s ecosystem role extends to the human capital pipeline. By embedding universities in each KIC, the EIT ensures that education and training are part of the innovation process, not separate from it. Students and researchers at partner universities are exposed to entrepreneurship and real-world application via KIC programs (for example, Master and PhD students in EIT-labelled programs work on industry-proposed innovation projects and often intern at KIC partner companies). Conversely, industry partners contribute to curricula, offer case studies, and sometimes provide guest lecturers or mentors, aligning skills with market needs ⁷⁶
⁷⁸ . This creates a virtuous cycle: KICs produce “T-shaped” professionals (deep in a field, but broad skills in business/innovation) who are readily absorbed by the ecosystem ⁷⁶ . The EIT Alumni network further sustains connections among graduates, many of whom go on to found start-ups or take innovation roles in companies.
- **Regional and Civic Actors:** Uniquely, some KICs actively involve cities, regions, and public authorities as partners, recognizing that innovation often requires systemic adoption. This is prominent in **EIT Urban Mobility**, where city municipalities (like Barcelona, Amsterdam, Stockholm) are core consortium members, working together with transport companies and tech firms on urban solutions. The cities provide living labs for piloting smart mobility solutions and help navigate regulatory barriers. Similarly, **EIT Climate-KIC** has partnered with city networks and regional clusters to drive climate action programs at a systems level (e.g. orchestrating “Deep Demonstrations” of climate innovation in certain cities/regions). The inclusion of public-sector stakeholders helps in scaling innovations and aligning them with policy (e.g. integrating an EIT-developed solution into a city’s climate plan or a region’s smart specialization strategy).

In summary, the EIT Communities act as *innovation orchestrators*, breaking down silos between academia and industry and fostering cross-sector collaboration. They create dense networks of trust and knowledge exchange – an entrepreneur in an EIT accelerator can easily connect with a scientist at a partner university or an investor from a corporate partner. By **collaborating with 2,400+ partner organizations and 1000s of innovators across Europe** ⁵ , the EIT has built an ecosystem where ideas, talent, and technology circulate efficiently, aiming to replicate the innovation-conducive environments seen in places like Silicon Valley, but at a European scale.

Impact on Education and Entrepreneurship

Entrepreneurial Education and EIT-Labelled Degrees: Education is a fundamental pillar of the EIT’s mission to nurture the next generation of innovators. To this end, each KIC operates educational programs that span formal degrees to informal training, all emphasizing innovation and entrepreneurship. A hallmark of quality in these programs is the **EIT Label** – a certificate awarded by the EIT to top-tier curricula that meet specific excellence criteria in fostering innovation, interdisciplinarity, and business skills ⁷⁹ . Many KIC-affiliated universities have developed **EIT-Labelled Master’s and PhD programs** in fields related to the KIC’s theme. For example, EIT InnoEnergy’s Master School offers degrees in Sustainable Energy Engineering that not only teach technical skills but also include modules on entrepreneurship, innovation management, and even a mobility scheme to study at multiple partner universities across Europe ⁸⁰ ⁸¹ . Likewise, EIT Digital’s Master School covers topics like data science or autonomous systems with integrated business courses, and EIT Health’s campuses offer programs in Health Innovation. The EIT Label ensures these

programs “develop practical skills in innovation and entrepreneurship, moving beyond theory to tackle real-world challenges” ⁷⁹ . Students often work on projects in collaboration with KIC industry partners and have access to KIC innovation facilities. By 2013, the first EIT-labelled degrees had been launched as pilot “role model” programs for hands-on, entrepreneurial education ⁸² . This approach has scaled up – **over 880,000 learners** have taken part in EIT education and training offerings to date ⁸³ , ranging from degree students to professionals upskilling through short courses. Moreover, the EIT Community has set up initiatives for lifelong learning, such as online courses (e.g. EIT Digital’s Professional School) and summer schools. These not only address the high-tech skills gap in Europe but also imbue participants with an innovation mindset. EIT Alumni often credit the programs for helping them become founders or tech leaders. The EIT has also recently launched the **HEI Initiative** (Higher Education Initiative) to support universities in building innovation capacity, further solidifying the link between academia and entrepreneurship ¹⁶ .

Startup Creation and Accelerator Support: On the entrepreneurship side, the EIT has become a major catalyst for venture creation in Europe. All KICs run **incubators or accelerators tailored to their sector**, providing venture coaching, access to labs, market validation, and often direct funding. For example, Climate-KIC’s Accelerator is a three-stage program that has supported hundreds of climate-tech startups (in areas like clean mobility, sustainable agriculture, etc.) with grants, mentorship and investor networks. EIT Health’s Accelerator similarly supports health tech startups through bootcamps and provides opportunities to pilot innovations in hospitals of its network. EIT Food runs seedbed incubators for agrifood entrepreneurs across its partner regions. These programs frequently culminate in demo days or competitions (like **EIT Jumpstarter**, a cross-KIC pre-accelerator for idea-stage entrepreneurs in RIS regions ⁸⁴). In addition, KICs have specialized venture support schemes: EIT Digital’s Venture Program invests in early-stage deep tech, and EIT InnoEnergy not only incubates but also directly finances energy startups (it has a dedicated fund and is an active shareholder in several scale-ups). This comprehensive support has yielded a robust pipeline of new companies: as of 2025, the EIT community has *directly supported over 9,900 start-ups and scale-ups* through its various business creation instruments ⁸³ . These ventures benefit not just from money and training, but also the credibility and exposure of being connected to the EIT. The KICs often help startups secure follow-on investments by leveraging their corporate and investor contacts – collectively, EIT-supported ventures have attracted nearly **€10 billion** in external investment capital to date ⁸³ . Some KICs also operate **accelerator offices in Silicon Valley or other global innovation hubs** to help their startups expand internationally.

An important aspect of EIT’s entrepreneurship strategy is its focus on developing *entrepreneurs themselves*. Beyond supporting existing startups, KIC programs encourage students and researchers to become founders. Many EIT Label degree students form startups during or after their studies, often with the help of KIC innovation grants (for prototyping or market research). The EIT Alumni network and annual **EIT Awards** (which celebrate outstanding entrepreneurs, innovators, and graduates from the KICs) create an inspirational community and provide role models. The EIT’s impact on entrepreneurship is also visible in the formation of cross-border startup teams; for instance, founders from different EU countries often meet through KIC hackathons or summer schools and go on to create joint ventures, embodying the European dimension of the EIT.

Overall, the synergy of *education + incubation* has been a defining feature of the EIT model. By coupling **EIT-labelled educational excellence** with **on-the-ground venture support**, the Institute not only equips individuals with the skills to innovate but also provides the launchpad to turn those innovations into real businesses. This integrated approach addresses a traditional gap in Europe’s innovation system – the

difficulty of translating research talent and ideas into successful enterprises – by supporting the entire journey from classroom to company.

Achievements, Impact Metrics, and Major Successes

After over a decade of operations, the EIT has accumulated a strong track record of outputs and impacts, as evidenced by key performance metrics and success stories across its KICs. **By the numbers, the EIT Community's achievements (cumulatively up to 2024) include:**

- **Ventures Created/Supported:** More than **9,900 start-ups and scale-ups** have been supported by EIT KICs, many of which were newly created through KIC programs ⁸³. These ventures span sectors from renewable energy to medtech to creative industries, and form a vibrant pipeline of European innovation. Not only have thousands of new companies been launched, but KICs have also helped these companies survive and grow: by providing early investment and market access, the EIT has incubated firms that now generate significant revenue and jobs. Notably, the collective valuation of EIT-supported companies exceeds **€70 billion** as of 2025 ⁵, indicating several have scaled to become “unicorns” or industry leaders. For instance, **Northvolt**, a Swedish battery manufacturer backed early by EIT InnoEnergy, has grown into Europe’s foremost lithium-ion battery producer, now valued in the billions and central to the EU’s Battery Alliance ⁸⁵. Likewise, EIT InnoEnergy boasts at least **4 unicorns** in its portfolio (e.g. Northvolt, Verkor, Skeleton Technologies, etc.), reflecting its impact in the cleantech domain ⁸⁶ ⁸⁷. In climate and health sectors, too, EIT-supported ventures like **Climeworks** (direct air capture of CO₂) or **BioNTech** (which received early EIT Health support) have achieved global prominence.
- **Innovation Outputs:** KIC projects have developed and launched over **2,400 new products, services or processes** into the market ⁸³. These range from tangible technologies – such as novel biomedical devices, renewable energy solutions, advanced materials – to software platforms and creative content. For example, by 2020 Climate-KIC alone had launched 469 innovative products/services, contributing to an estimated **13 million tonnes of CO₂-equivalent emissions avoided per year** through climate solutions ⁸⁸. Many of these innovations have won awards; several EIT Digital-supported technologies in AI and cybersecurity have been adopted by industry; EIT Food innovations are improving food safety and sustainability in supply chains. The high number of products on the market is a testament to the focus on applied innovation – KIC projects are not just academic publications, but tangible innovations reaching end-users.
- **Learners Trained and Graduates:** As mentioned, over **880,000 people** have undergone training or education through EIT programs ⁸³. This includes more than 4,600 EIT Label graduates (master’s and PhDs) who have earned degrees from KIC partner universities ⁴⁶, plus hundreds of thousands who took part in short courses, online training (e.g. during the COVID-19 pandemic, KICs rapidly offered free online courses on entrepreneurship), and outreach initiatives (like coding schools for youth via EIT Digital or innovation workshops for citizens under various KICs). The impact of this is harder to quantify, but many alumni have gone on to important roles. Additionally, the EIT’s professional education arm (like EIT Manufacturing’s upskilling courses for workers) addresses skills gaps in European industries, contributing to workforce development in emerging areas (e.g. battery tech, AI, climate adaptation planning).

- **Jobs and Economic Value:** Through venture creation and innovation projects, the KICs have made a dent in job creation. EIT InnoEnergy reports that its supported companies alone created **40,000+ jobs** in clean tech over the past decade ⁸⁹. Across all KICs, the figure is likely higher when including indirect employment. In terms of economic stimulus, the nearly €10 billion in outside investment mobilized by EIT ventures ⁸³ indicates substantial capital flowing into European innovation as a result of EIT's leverage (the EIT cites a *leverage ratio* of 5.6, meaning for every €1 of EIT money, about €5.6 is attracted from other sources ⁸³). This is an impressive multiplier effect, illustrating efficient use of public funds to crowd-in private investment. Startups graduating from KIC accelerators have raised significant venture capital rounds – for example, in 2023 alone, multiple EIT Health startups (like AI medical imaging firms) closed multi-million euro Series A financings, and EIT Urban Mobility startups in micromobility saw major corporate acquisitions.
- **Notable Initiatives and Projects:** The EIT has spearheaded or contributed to several high-profile EU initiatives. A prime example is the **European Battery Alliance (EBA)**, which EIT InnoEnergy has been coordinating on behalf of the European Commission ⁸⁵. Through the EBA250 platform, InnoEnergy helped launch dozens of battery value-chain projects (factories, training programs) critical to Europe's clean energy transition, aligning with Green Deal goals. Similarly, EIT Climate-KIC's **"Deep Demonstrations"** program has been working on holistic climate innovation in areas like resilient cities and just transition for coal regions, feeding into EU policy pilots. EIT Food has major projects supporting the Farm-to-Fork strategy – for instance, sustainable agriculture accelerators and living labs for regenerative farming. EIT Urban Mobility contributed to the EU's smart cities agenda through projects on autonomous shuttles and urban air quality improvements in member cities. The KICs also collaborated during crises: in 2020, the EIT launched a €60 million **COVID-19 Crisis Response Initiative**, via which the KICs rapidly funded nearly 200 COVID-related innovations (from diagnostic tools to e-learning solutions) to help address the pandemic and its economic fallout ⁹⁰. This agile response was highlighted as a success in demonstrating the EIT Community's ability to mobilize in emergency situations.

Beyond raw numbers, it is worth noting the **growing recognition** of the EIT's model in Europe's innovation landscape. In 2024, an independent analysis by *Sifted* (Financial Times) ranked the EIT as the **top public investor** in European startups, outperforming traditional venture capital in backing successful ventures ⁹¹ ⁸³. This kind of external validation underscores that the KIC approach – combining education, business support, and research – is yielding tangible results. The EIT has also become a reference point for other innovation programs; for example, some national governments have emulated the knowledge triangle model in their own innovation hubs, and the EU's newer programs (like the European Innovation Council) are designed to complement, not duplicate, the EIT's work (the EIC focuses more on direct funding to individual startups, whereas the EIT builds ecosystems).

Achievements do vary by KIC, and the EIT has openly acknowledged challenges in some cases. But collectively, the nine KICs have created a new paradigm for EU innovation and achieved a critical mass of results: thousands of innovations and companies that contribute to Europe's competitiveness and to societal goals (climate action, healthy living, digital leadership, etc.). Many EIT-born solutions are directly improving citizens' lives – from renewable energy installations to health diagnostics to smart mobility apps in cities. These achievements position the EIT as a key delivery instrument for European innovation ambitions.

Integration into EU Policy Priorities (Green Deal, Digital Decade, etc.)

The EIT and its KICs are tightly aligned with, and actively contribute to, the European Union's broader policy agenda for innovation, sustainability, and digital transformation. This is by design: the thematic focus of KICs directly maps onto EU priority areas, and the EIT's activities are geared toward implementing EU strategies such as the Green Deal and Digital Decade.

European Green Deal: A cornerstone of EU policy is the European Green Deal, which aims to make Europe the first climate-neutral continent by 2050 and transform the economy for sustainability. The EIT Community is a crucial implementation arm in this effort. **EIT Climate-KIC** is specifically oriented to climate innovation and has been a key player in driving low-carbon solutions (renewable energy, climate-resilient agriculture, circular economy innovations) that feed into Green Deal objectives ⁹² ³⁶ . It partners with cities and regions on decarbonization roadmaps, providing innovation input to initiatives like the EU Mission on Climate-Neutral Cities. **EIT InnoEnergy** and **EIT RawMaterials** underpin the Green Deal's industrial and energy pillars: InnoEnergy's work on batteries, solar PV, smart grids and energy storage directly supports the transition to clean energy and electrification of transport (a Green Deal priority), while RawMaterials addresses secure and sustainable supply of critical raw materials essential for green technologies ³⁶ . Indeed, these KICs have been involved in EU industrial alliances (Battery Alliance, Raw Materials Alliance) that are part of the Green Deal's execution. **EIT Urban Mobility** contributes to the Green Deal's sustainable and smart mobility goals by accelerating the deployment of zero-emission transport solutions and new mobility services in cities. **EIT Food** supports the Farm-to-Fork strategy by fostering agritech and alternative proteins for a more sustainable food system (e.g. supporting startups in plant-based foods, reducing food waste, etc.). **EIT Manufacturing** promotes greener and more efficient production processes, aligned with the EU's circular economy and advanced manufacturing agendas. In sum, through its KIC projects and startups, the EIT delivers innovations that help meet the Green Deal's targets in energy, mobility, agriculture, and climate adaptation. Policymakers have tapped KIC expertise in advisory groups, and KICs often ensure that regulatory and market barriers are communicated back to EU legislators, creating a two-way exchange. The integrated approach of KICs (education, innovation, business) also means developing the *skills* and industrial supply chains needed for the green transition – something emphasized in the Green Deal (e.g. reskilling for green jobs, which KICs like InnoEnergy address via battery academies and other programs ⁹³ ⁹⁴).

Digital Decade and Europe's Digital Strategy: The EU's "Digital Decade" policy outlines targets for 2030 in areas like digital skills, infrastructure, and digitalization of businesses and public services ⁹⁵ . The EIT, particularly through **EIT Digital**, is a major instrument to advance these goals. EIT Digital's focus on frontier tech (artificial intelligence, cybersecurity, fintech, etc.) and on cultivating digital talent (through its Master School and professional courses) contributes to the EU's aim of digital leadership and autonomy. For example, EIT Digital has incubated ventures in AI and quantum computing that align with Europe's effort to build sovereign capabilities in critical technologies. It also works on pan-European projects for digital cities, digital industry and tech infrastructure that support the EU's Digital Strategy (such as projects improving cross-border digital connectivity or public service platforms). Meanwhile, other KICs integrate digitalization within their domains: **EIT Health** leverages digital health innovations (telemedicine, health data analytics) in line with the Digital Decade's emphasis on e-health. **EIT Urban Mobility** supports smart city platforms and connected vehicles; **EIT Manufacturing** drives Industry 4.0 adoption in factories. The KICs have thus been key promoters of the EU's concept of *twin transition* – the simultaneous green and digital transformation of

Europe's economy ⁹⁶ ⁹⁷. Notably, the EIT's inclusion in Horizon Europe Pillar 3 (Innovative Europe) alongside the EIC indicates its role in delivering the technological and innovation objectives of the EU, while Pillar 2 addresses thematic R&D and Pillar 1 basic science. The EIT's cross-cutting approach means it often links digital solutions to green applications (e.g. EIT Climate-KIC working on climate fintech, or EIT InnoEnergy on digital tools for energy management), supporting the EU goal that digital innovation should also contribute to sustainability ⁹⁷.

Other EU Agendas: The EIT also feeds into the **EU Skills Agenda** and initiatives like the *New European Innovation Agenda (2022)*, which calls for bolstering Europe's innovation ecosystems and talent retention. The EIT's education programs, support for women entrepreneurs (several KICs have campaigns to increase female participation in tech), and regional inclusion through RIS directly respond to these policy priorities. Additionally, KICs have aligned with missions and partnerships under Horizon Europe; for instance, EIT Climate-KIC contributes to the Climate Adaptation and Cities Missions, and EIT Health to the Cancer Mission via health innovation projects. KICs in areas like raw materials and manufacturing are closely linked with the EU's industrial strategy (ensuring resilience in critical supply chains and technological sovereignty). The EIT is increasingly seen as a platform to **integrate policy with practice**: it not only responds to policies but helps shape them by demonstrating innovative solutions on the ground. For example, successful pilots by KIC startups can inform EU regulatory changes (as seen when some EIT-supported mobility solutions helped guide new mobility regulations in cities). The EIT's multi-actor setup also embodies the *Triple/Quadruple Helix* model championed in EU innovation policy, incorporating civil society (especially through its climate and urban KICs) into innovation processes.

In conclusion, the EIT serves as a **bridge between high-level EU policy goals and concrete innovative actions**. By aligning KIC thematic priorities with EU strategies like the Green Deal and Digital Decade, the EIT ensures that its outputs (startups, innovations, skilled people) directly advance the EU's agenda for a green, digital, and competitive Europe ⁷. The synergy is mutual: EU policies provide strategic direction and funding to the EIT, while the EIT provides the means (and success stories) to realize those policies' ambitions on the ground.

Challenges, Critiques, and Future Directions

Despite its successes, the EIT model has faced **critiques and challenges** that have prompted reflection on its future evolution, especially as the EU plans for the next Framework Programme (FP10, post-2027). Key issues include questions about the EIT's added value relative to other instruments, internal operational challenges, and how to ensure its long-term sustainability and impact.

Overlap and Added Value: One critique raised (notably by some Member States) is that the EIT's activities sometimes appear to overlap with other EU programs, potentially complicating the innovation support landscape. For instance, the **educational offerings of KICs** – such as entrepreneurship training and student mobility – have been seen by some as overlapping with Erasmus+ or Marie Curie Actions ⁹⁸. In a 2024 position paper, the Danish government went so far as to suggest “the time has come to discontinue the EIT as a separate entity,” arguing that stakeholders found it “*difficult to identify added value*” and that perhaps its functions could be merged into other programs ⁹⁹. They pointed out that the **European Innovation Council (EIC)**, launched in 2021 to fund breakthrough start-ups, covers some similar ground in scaling companies, and that there may be redundancy in having both the EIC and EIT structures ¹⁰⁰ ¹⁰¹. This critique essentially questions whether maintaining a standalone institute (with its administrative overhead and complex KIC grant model) is justified.

The EIT's leadership has responded by highlighting the **unique aspects** of the EIT model: its focus on integrating education and community-building (which the EIC does not do), its thematic ecosystem approach (versus the EIC's individual company funding), and its track record of sustainable partnerships ¹⁰² ¹⁰³. In an interview, EIT Director Martin Kern noted that the oldest KICs achieving financial sustainability is proof that the model works and creates partnerships that "*become sustainable*" on their own ²⁰. He cited the example that EIT InnoEnergy reached a valuation near €1 billion, indicating a self-sustaining innovation engine ¹⁰⁴. The **added value** of the EIT, proponents argue, lies in this long-term ecosystem capacity that cannot be achieved by grant funding alone. Nonetheless, the discussion of possible **merger or restructuring** (like folding EIT into the EIC or vice versa) is on the table as the Commission and Member States debate the optimal innovation support landscape for FP10 ¹⁰⁵. It is acknowledged that the EIC and EIT have "very different mandates and models" – one focusing on individual deep-tech ventures, the other on broader capacity-building – so any integration would need to reconcile these differences ¹⁰⁶. The mid-term evaluation of Horizon Europe (expected in 2025) will likely address this and could recommend adjustments in governance or scope of the EIT ¹⁰⁷.

Operational and Financial Challenges: Within the KIC operations, several challenges have been observed. One is the **path to financial sustainability** for KICs. The goal was for KICs to become independent of EIT funding after 10–15 years, but in practice this is demanding. While the first wave KICs (Climate, Digital, InnoEnergy) have indeed greatly reduced their reliance on EIT grants by 2024 ²⁰, they still seek some continued EU support (there are discussions about modest extension grants or new roles for them) ¹⁰⁸. Later-wave KICs (like those started in 2015 or 2018) will similarly face the challenge of replacing EIT funding with other revenue by the end of their seven-year grant cycles. Generating stable income – whether through membership fees, services, or equity returns from startups – has proven tricky, especially if a KIC's theme is not immediately lucrative. Some critics worried that KICs might become too commercially driven and stray from their knowledge-sharing mission in the pursuit of income. On the flip side, others feared that without continued public funding, the partnerships might disintegrate once the EU money dries up. The EIT Governing Board's "**Financial Sustainability**" strategy tries to address this by setting intermediate targets and encouraging KICs to develop revenue streams (for example, EIT RawMaterials offers consultancy services to industry, EIT Food has some fee-for-service programs, etc.) ⁴⁸. Ensuring each KIC's longevity beyond EU subsidies remains a key challenge.

Another issue has been **administrative complexity**. The KIC model, with many partners and sub-grants, is inherently complex to manage. In early years, some KICs struggled with cumbersome processes and delays in funding disbursement. The requirement to juggle multiple funding sources and report on numerous KPIs was seen as heavy bureaucracy by participants. The EIT has worked to simplify and harmonize some of these processes (for example, introducing a common cost-nomenclature and KPI framework across KICs), but striking the right balance between accountability and agility is an ongoing task. An external review noted the model was "*innovative and experimental*" – which is positive, but also meant learning by doing for governance and financial models ¹⁰⁹.

Innovation Gap and Diversity: The EIT has explicitly aimed to bridge Europe's East-West innovation gap via RIS, and while progress is evident (with more involvement of Eastern and Southern Europe than before, and RIS hubs booming ⁵⁶), there are still gaps to fill. Some countries still participate less in KICs (possibly due to less local capacity or awareness). The EIT will need to ensure the new RIS hubs translate into sustained partnerships and that talent in those regions gets the same support. Diversity is another focus: ensuring women are equally represented in entrepreneurship (the tech sector's gender gap reflects in EIT activities

too, though KICs have women-in-tech initiatives). The KICs must also keep evolving their thematic focus to stay relevant – e.g. incorporating the latest technology trends (AI, robotics, etc.) across domains.

Future Directions: Looking ahead, the EIT and its Governing Board have laid out a vision for the institute's next chapter (2028–2035) that addresses these challenges and capitalizes on opportunities. In a **Future Vision paper** released by the EIT Board, they propose expanding into new thematic areas where Europe faces emerging challenges – such as **security and civil protection technologies, artificial intelligence and robotics, and perhaps rural innovation** – potentially via new KICs or initiatives ¹¹⁰. This indicates the EIT might diversify beyond the current set of nine KIC sectors to remain at the cutting-edge of innovation needs. Indeed, the forthcoming **EIT Water** KIC (planned for 2025 launch) is one such expansion into a crucial area (water, marine and maritime innovation) ³⁹ ³⁸. The Board also emphasizes the need to **further close the innovation divide**: one concept is a “*Regional Innovation Booster*” to strengthen startup creation specifically in Central, Eastern, and Southern Europe, and improve access to finance in those regions ¹¹⁰ ¹¹¹. This likely builds on the RIS to provide even more targeted support (perhaps co-investment funds or scaled-up Jumpstarter programs).

Another priority is enhancing the **EIT's role in human capital development**. The Board envisions an “*EIT Innovation Campus*” concept to streamline access to all EIT education and training across KICs, with a focus on industry needs and inclusion of underrepresented groups (like increasing the participation of women in entrepreneurship, something the Board explicitly notes) ¹¹¹. This could mean a more unified EIT education brand or platform (already we see steps like the *Deep Tech Talent Initiative* which is a cross-KIC pledge to train people in deep tech skills).

Crucially, future directions involve **stronger synergies with other EU instruments**. The EIT plans to align and cooperate more systematically with entities like the EIC, European Investment Bank (EIB/EIF), and other EU initiatives to create a “*pipeline of support*” from idea to scale-up ¹¹². Instead of viewing EIC as a competitor, the idea is to have a continuum: fundamental research (ERC) feeds into applied innovation (EIT KICs) which creates startups that can then get scale-up funding (EIC), with the EIT providing the ecosystem and skills at each step. The mid-2020s debate on EIT's future is likely to refine its role vis-à-vis the EIC, possibly formalizing collaborations (already a 2021 MoU was signed between EIT and EIC ¹¹³).

From a **policy integration** standpoint, the EIT will undoubtedly be called upon to support new EU flagship initiatives – whether it's the Green Deal's later stages (hydrogen economy, renovation wave, etc.) or the digital/tech sovereignty push (semiconductors, Web4.0, etc.). Given current discussions, we may see the EIT KIC model applied to fields like **security/defence innovation** (which is novel for the EU, but the Board explicitly mentions exploring a KIC in civil security technologies) ¹¹⁴. The success of any such expansion will depend on securing political and financial support in the next EU budget.

In summary, while the EIT has proven its model in many respects, it stands at a crossroads where it must address criticisms and adapt. Ensuring clearer **added value** (possibly by better communicating its impact and differentiating its role from other instruments) is one task – the 2024 Danish critique underscores a need for the EIT to articulate how it complements, not duplicates, other efforts ⁹⁸. Improving **efficiency and simplification** in KIC operations will help keep partners engaged (reducing red tape so innovators can innovate). Financially, the EIT likely will develop new funding modalities (maybe incentivizing private co-investors to support KIC activities, or a revolving fund from equity exits of startups) to bolster sustainability. The concept of a more **open, flexible EIT** is on the horizon: the EIT might share its expertise through advisory services to Member States or help incubate innovation hubs outside its own structure.

The **next Strategic Innovation Agenda (2028–2034)** will formalize these directions. Importantly, broad support exists in the European Parliament and among innovation leaders to continue the EIT – MEPs who were champions of EIT (like Maria da Graça Carvalho) advocate for its preservation, even if integrated more with the EIC ¹⁰⁵. The European Commission has indicated “everything is on the table” as it evaluates how EIT can best serve the EU innovation ecosystem going forward ¹⁰⁶.

Whatever governance tweaks occur, the consensus is that the challenges EIT addresses (innovation gap, need for entrepreneurial talent, etc.) remain vital. Thus the **future EIT** will likely see a reinvigorated mandate: focusing on Europe’s next big challenges (digital age, green transition, tech sovereignty) with possibly a leaner structure and tighter synergy with EU’s innovation funding chain. As one Commission official noted, the goal is to show convincingly that “*without the EIT this EU innovation ecosystem cannot continue*” ¹¹⁵ – a challenge the EIT community appears ready to meet by evolving and demonstrating impact in the years ahead.

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4. Science|Business – *EIT director “surprised” by proposal to discontinue agency* (Martin Kern interview, Feb 2024) ¹²¹ ¹²². Discusses the debate on EIT’s future under FP10. Kern emphasizes the EIT’s “specific model” is delivering: **mission & activities** – launched 2008 to integrate education, research, innovation; nine KICs tackling specific challenges, focusing on entrepreneurial education, innovation projects, and business creation ¹²³. **Financial sustainability**: KICs are meant to become independent after ~15 years. The first three KICs (Climate, InnoEnergy, Digital, set up 2010) have

“now achieved this” according to Kern – their EIT funding ends by end of 2024, though an extension is being discussed ²⁰. Kern calls it “great” that partnerships become sustainable; notes EIT InnoEnergy’s valuation is ~€1 billion as evidence of success ¹²⁴. **Overlap debate:** Some propose merging EIT with the newer EIC (European Innovation Council) to streamline support for start-ups ¹⁰⁰. A Danish government paper argued to discontinue EIT as separate, claiming stakeholders struggle to see added value and pointing out overlaps (KIC education vs Erasmus+, some EIC vs EIT project overlaps) ¹²⁵ ⁹⁸. Kern was surprised by this, and others like MEP Carvalho note EIC and EIT “probably don’t need to be two different agencies” ¹²⁶, with Commission’s R&I DG saying “everything is on the table” ahead of Horizon Europe mid-term review ¹⁰⁶. The Commission’s Normunds Popena acknowledged EIT’s success but said budget pressures mean hard discussions; proponents need to make the case for EIT to remain a distinct instrument in the future ¹¹⁵.

5. EIT News – *EIT Recognized as Europe’s Top Investor in Sifted’s 2024 Ranking* (Jan 2025) ¹²⁷ ¹²⁸. Reports that the EIT ranked #1 in Sifted’s list of top public/private startup investors in Europe, reflecting the success of the EIT Community. **Impact metrics:** EIT has *directly supported 9,900+ ventures, brought 2,400+ new products to market, and trained 880,000+ learners* ⁸³. It has a leverage ratio of 5.6 (mobilized ~€10 billion external funding for start-ups) ⁸³. Its network of 70+ hubs ensures presence in every EU Member State ¹²⁹. These figures highlight the EIT’s extensive impact on startups, innovation output, and skill development.
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8. EIT Urban Mobility – *About us* (webpage, accessed 2023) ³². States that the EIT Urban Mobility Association is a non-profit legal entity **established in 2019**, based in Barcelona (under Catalonia’s laws) ³². This confirms Urban Mobility’s launch year and HQ location, reflecting the fourth-wave KIC setup.

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